suddenly and primally that it wipes out all other feeling, all thought besides helpless resignation. My life was over. I slumped in my chair, a big black padded Aeron that tilted underneath me as I fell into a void and lost consciousness.

I came to still seated, with the clock on my desk reading just shy of 1:00 p.m. I'd been out less than an hour, but I was exhausted. It was as if I'd been awake since the beginning of time.

I reached for the phone in a panic, but my hand kept missing it and grabbing the air. Once I managed to grab ahold of it and get a dial tone, I found I couldn't remember Lindsay's number, or could only remember the digits but not their order.

Somehow I managed to get myself downstairs, taking each step deliberately, palm against the wall. I got some juice out of the fridge and chugged it, keeping both hands on the carton and dribbling a fair amount on my chin. Then I lay down on the floor, pressed my cheek to the cool linoleum, and fell asleep, which was how Lindsay found me.

I'd just had an epileptic seizure.

My mother had epilepsy, and for a time at least was prone to grand mal seizures: the foaming at the mouth, her limbs thrashing, her body rolling around until it stilled into a horrible unconscious rigidity. I couldn't believe I hadn't previously associated my symptoms with hers, though that was the very same denial she herself had been in for decades, attributing her frequent falls to "clumsiness" and "lack of coordination." She hadn't been diagnosed until her first grand mal in her late thirties, and, after a brief spell on medication, her seizures stopped. She'd always told me and my sister that epilepsy wasn't hereditary and to this day I'm still not sure if that's what her doctor had told her or if she was just trying to reassure us that her fate wouldn't be ours.

There is no diagnostic test for epilepsy. The clinical diagnosis is just two or more unexplained seizures—that's it. Very little is known about the condition. Medicine tends to treat epilepsy phenomenologically. Doctors don't talk about "epilepsy," they talk about "seizures." They tend to divide seizures into two types: localized and generalized, the former being an electrical misfire in a certain section of your brain that doesn't spread, the latter being an electrical misfire that creates a chain reaction. Basically, a wave of misfiring synapses rolls across your brain, causing you to lose motor function and, ultimately, consciousness.

Epilepsy is such a strange syndrome. Its sufferers feel different things, depending on which part of their brain has the initial electrical cascade failure.